

DATASET DOCUMENTATION

Startup Founder Burnout & Failure Risk Dataset

A synthetic dataset simulating founder psychology, startup operating conditions, burnout progression, and startup survival dynamics.

File name	startup_founder_burnout_2026_final.csv
Records	50,000 rows
Features	29 columns
Missing values	None
Format	CSV, UTF-8
Domain	Startups · Mental Health · Business Analytics

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1. Dataset Overview

This dataset is a realistic **synthetic simulation** of startup founder behavior, burnout patterns, business pressure, and startup survival dynamics. It combines founder psychology, startup operating conditions, economic environments, growth metrics, and startup failure risk into a single, machine-learning-ready table.

Most public startup datasets focus narrowly on funding and revenue metrics. This dataset instead emphasizes the **human side** of entrepreneurship — founder burnout, sleep deprivation, decision fatigue, cofounder conflict, and work-life balance — alongside the operational and financial indicators that ultimately determine whether a startup survives.

50,000 Founder Records	29 Total Features	0 Missing Values	5 Feature Categories
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Primary Use Cases

- Founder burnout prediction (classification & regression)
- Startup failure / shutdown risk modeling
- Behavioral analytics and founder-archetype clustering
- Explainable AI (SHAP) and feature-importance analysis
- Dashboarding and business-intelligence prototyping

2. Methodology & Realism Design

The dataset was generated using probabilistic simulation, behavioral modeling, nonlinear correlations, stochastic noise generation, and economic condition simulation. Several real-world relationships were intentionally modeled into the data-generating process:

- Longer weekly work hours reduce sleep quality and duration
- Rising burnout scores increase startup failure risk
- Investor pressure increases founder stress
- Cofounder conflict reduces overall startup stability
- Recessions and funding winters negatively affect startup survival

To mimic the unpredictability of real startup ecosystems, the generator also introduces rare contradictions and edge cases — for example, high-performing but exhausted founders, healthy founders facing market collapse, and resilient founders operating under extreme pressure. This produces a dataset with realistic behavioral noise rather than perfectly clean, linear relationships.

Disclaimer: This dataset is entirely synthetic and does not contain real personal or confidential founder data. It was inspired by startup ecosystem trends, entrepreneurial burnout research, startup failure studies, and founder mental-health reports.

3. Feature Documentation by Category

3.1 Founder & Firmographic Attributes

Baseline attributes describing the founder and the startup itself — who they are, what stage the company has reached, and the environment it operates in.

Founder_Type

Categorical (8 values)

The founder's behavioral/personality archetype, e.g. Visionary CEO, Solo Hustler, Technical Builder, Serial Entrepreneur, Calm Operator, Burned-Out Operator, Chaotic Innovator, Growth Obsessed Founder. Used to segment founders into psychologically meaningful groups for clustering and behavioral analysis.

Economic_Climate

Categorical (4 values)

The macro-economic backdrop at the time the record was captured: Bull Market, Stable Economy, Funding Winter, or Recession. Drives downstream variation in investor pressure, growth, and shutdown probability.

Founder_Age

Integer (21–61)

The founder's age in years. Provides a demographic dimension for exploring how age relates to resilience, burnout, and decision-making.

Founder_Experience_Years

Integer (0–12)

Years of relevant prior professional experience the founder had before starting this venture. A proxy for domain expertise and preparedness.

Industry

Categorical (10 values)

The sector the startup operates in, e.g. AI, SaaS, FinTech, HealthTech, E-commerce, EdTech, Biotech, ClimateTech, Cybersecurity, Gaming.

Funding_Stage

Categorical, ordinal (6 values)

Current funding stage, ordered from Bootstrapped through Pre-Seed, Seed, Series A, Series B, to Series C. Reflects capital access and growth pressure.

Work_Mode

Categorical (3 values)

The company's predominant work arrangement: Remote, Hybrid, or Office.

Team_Size

Integer (1–799)

The number of people on the startup's team, spanning solo founders to large scale-ups.

Startup_Age_Months

Integer (2–143)

Age of the startup in months since founding, used to study how burnout and risk evolve over a company's lifecycle.

3.2 Lifestyle & Behavioral Metrics

Daily-life indicators that capture how the founder actually spends their time, and the toll (or balance) that results.

Weekly_Work_Hours

Float (28–110)

Average number of hours the founder works per week. A core driver of downstream burnout and sleep metrics.

Sleep_Hours

Float (2.8–9.0)

Average daily hours of sleep. Modeled to decline as weekly work hours rise.

Exercise_Days_Per_Week

Float (0–7)

Number of days per week the founder exercises — a protective lifestyle factor against burnout.

Vacation_Days_Taken

Float (0–35)

Number of vacation days taken by the founder, reflecting willingness/ability to disengage from work.

3.3 Psychological & Burnout Indicators

Scored measures of the founder's internal psychological state, culminating in an overall burnout assessment.

Investor_Pressure_Score

Float, scale 1–10

Level of pressure the founder perceives from investors regarding growth, milestones, and returns.

Cofounder_Conflict_Score

Float, scale 0–10

Severity of interpersonal conflict between co-founders, capturing team-stability risk.

Stress_Score

Float, scale 1–10

The founder's overall psychological stress level.

Decision_Fatigue_Score

Float, scale 1–10

Degree of decision fatigue — the mental depletion that comes from making many high-stakes decisions.

Burnout_Score

Float, scale 1–10

A composite score representing the founder's overall burnout severity, combining workload, sleep, stress, and pressure signals.

Burnout_Level

Categorical (3 values)

Qualitative burnout category derived from Burnout_Score: Low, Moderate, or Severe.

Founder_Burnout_Flag

Binary (0/1)

Binary indicator of whether the founder is experiencing burnout (1 = burned out, 0 = not burned out). Useful as a classification target.

Work_Life_Balance_Score

Float, scale 1–10

The founder's self-reported balance between work and personal life.

Seeks_Mental_Health_Support

Categorical, binary (Yes/No)

Whether the founder actively seeks mental-health support (e.g. therapy, coaching, peer support).

3.4 Business Performance Metrics

Operational and financial indicators describing how the startup itself is performing, independent of the founder's internal state.

Monthly_Revenue_Growth_Percent

Float (-45.0 to 74.7)

Month-over-month revenue growth rate, expressed as a percentage. Negative values represent revenue contraction.

Runway_Months_Remaining

Float (1–36)

Number of months of cash runway remaining before the company runs out of funds at its current burn rate.

Product_Market_Fit_Score

Float, scale 1–10

A score representing how well the product currently satisfies market demand.

Employee_Turnover_Percent

Float (0–97.6)

The percentage rate at which employees leave the company, reflecting organizational health.

3.5 Outcome / Target Variables

The dependent variables of the dataset — the outcomes that predictive models are typically built to explain.

Shutdown_Probability**Float (0.0–0.998)**

A modeled probability, between 0 and 1, that the startup will shut down. Suitable as a regression target.

Shutdown_Risk**Categorical (3 values)**

Qualitative shutdown-risk category derived from Shutdown_Probability: Low, Medium, or High.

Startup_Failure_Flag**Binary (0/1)**

The dataset's primary classification target: whether the startup actually failed / shut down (1 = failed, 0 = did not fail).

4. Use Cases & ML Compatibility

The dataset is structured to support a wide range of machine-learning and analytics workflows out of the box:

Task Type	Suggested Target(s)	Notes
Classification	Founder_Burnout_Flag, Startup_Failure_Flag	Clean binary targets, ready for logistic regression, XGBoost, or LightGBM.
Regression	Burnout_Score, Shutdown_Probability	Continuous scores with nonlinear relationships to input features.
Clustering	Founder_Type, behavioral features	Segment founders into behavioral groups beyond the labeled archetype.
Explainable AI	Any target	Rich mix of categorical and numeric features suited to SHAP analysis.
Dashboards / BI	All features	No missing values and consistent scales simplify visualization work.

5. Quick-Reference Feature Table

A condensed summary of every feature in the dataset with a short description, for quick lookup.

Feature	Description
Founder_Type	Behavioral/personality archetype of the founder
Economic_Climate	Macro-economic condition at time of record
Founder_Age	Founder's age in years
Founder_Experience_Years	Founder's prior professional experience in years
Industry	Sector the startup operates in
Funding_Stage	Current funding stage of the startup
Work_Mode	Company's work arrangement (Remote/Hybrid/Office)
Team_Size	Number of people on the startup team
Startup_Age_Months	Startup's age in months since founding
Weekly_Work_Hours	Founder's average weekly work hours
Sleep_Hours	Founder's average daily sleep hours
Exercise_Days_Per_Week	Days per week the founder exercises
Vacation_Days_Taken	Vacation days taken by the founder
Investor_Pressure_Score	Pressure felt from investors (1–10)
Cofounder_Conflict_Score	Severity of co-founder conflict (0–10)
Stress_Score	Founder's overall stress level (1–10)
Decision_Fatigue_Score	Founder's decision fatigue level (1–10)
Burnout_Score	Founder's overall burnout severity (1–10)
Burnout_Level	Burnout category: Low / Moderate / Severe
Founder_Burnout_Flag	Binary flag: is the founder burned out?
Monthly_Revenue_Growth_Percent	Month-over-month revenue growth (%)
Runway_Months_Remaining	Months of cash runway remaining
Product_Market_Fit_Score	Product-market fit score (1–10)
Employee_Turnover_Percent	Employee turnover rate (%)
Work_Life_Balance_Score	Founder's work-life balance score (1–10)
Seeks_Mental_Health_Support	Whether founder seeks mental-health support (Yes/No)
Shutdown_Probability	Modeled probability of startup shutdown (0–1)

Feature	Description
Shutdown_Risk	Shutdown risk category: Low / Medium / High
Startup_Failure_Flag	Binary flag: did the startup actually fail?